

Ars Poetica

a poem to me is a little red wagon
one that my sister
had dad buy from Costco,
and one that we built up together
screwdrivers in hand.
at a time when I knew
righty tighty and lefty loosey
but couldn't tell apart
my lefts and rights
'cuz to me it was all rights
so long as my big sister was there,
us not apart but a part of a team.

now don't ask me why
but some how some way
we decided ~~she decided and I followed~~
it would be fun
to embark our precious stuffies
on a once in a lifetime journey
to a roller coaster ride
on our backyard hill

thinking back, in our naive naivety,
we must've forgotten to tighten the seatbelts
before inching the cart to the coaster's apex.
then with a final push ~~probably from me~~
the wagon was gone
down the steep grassy hill.
and together we watched it
jumping on the fallen branches and
slipping on the slick moss patches
before slamming handle-side first
into the prude oak tree
which once hung
dad's crude wooden swing.

of course, the animals all flew out—
weren't you listening?

the seatbelts were loose
and sure we were sad—
cried for a moment or four
for no moment more meant for
crying and
for no moment meant more for
us, and my poetry.

we put the panda, the horse, and the cat
altogether all together
in the little red wagon
and we guided it along
gently down the slope
until it rested at rest
at the feet of the hill
not defeated no, just
resting.

you see, a poem to me is a little red wagon
when I ship it off
on its one-way journey out to the world
it'll carry the weight of my
most precious memories
and deepest held emotions.

and when it
falls flat and fails or
stumbles in confusion,
I can always come around and
pack myself back in
as cargo, in the little red wagon.
just make sure to give it a hug and
massage smooth its bruises and
blow it a kiss before I let go again.

so there,
trip my little red wagon, it's okay—
weren't you listening?